



DOT ZONE

A Paper Game of Chance & Territory



Blue



Red

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Goals & Elevator Pitch

Roll the dice. Draw the lines. Claim your territory.

Accessible

Pen, paper, and two dice. No app, no setup, minimal barrier to entry.

Strategic

Every dot you place is a decision. Plan your region; or invade theirs.

Replayable

No two games are the same. Dot placement creates an infinite design space.

Players & Design Space

There are no “characters” - but every player inhabits a role/ playstyle

**2 – 4
players**



The Builder

Clusters dots densely in their region, creating many small, easy-to-close zones.
Reliable scoring, low risk.



The Disruptor

Spreads dots into contested space to block opponent geometry. Spends lines defensively to deny zones.



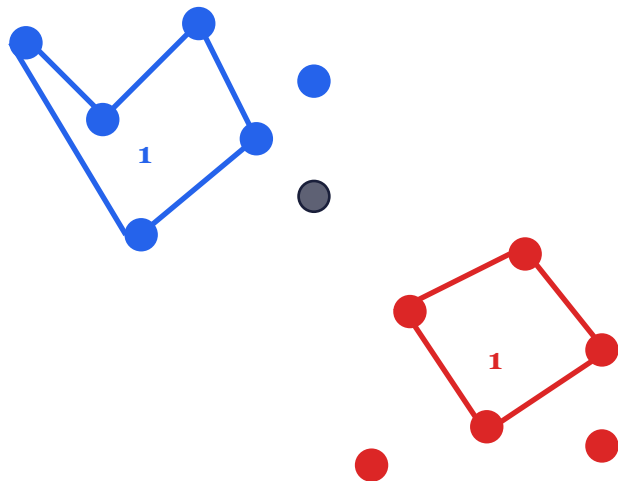
The Overreacher

Aggressively claims the middle, creating big zones — but risks gifting closures to the opponent.

Luck lives in the roll; 2d4 gives a bell curve of 2-8, keeping catastrophic turns rare and skill relevant.

The Board as the World

The paper is the game world. It evolves with every dot and line.



Sample Board State

• Blue dots — placed in setup, starting from one side of the page

• Red dots — placed in setup, starting from the opposite side

— Lines connect any two dots — but cannot cross existing lines

◆ Dots act as junctions — max 4 lines per dot

Scores written inside captured zones — bigger number needs bigger zone

Game Phases & Design Space

01

Setup

Players alternate placing dots freely on paper. Min 2 rounds each, stop when both are satisfied. Starting positions on opposite ends shape territorial logic.

02

Play

Roll 2d4 each turn to earn line credits. Draw lines between any two dots — no crossing, no redrawing, max 4 lines per dot. Closing a shape captures the zone.

03

Scoring

Write your ascending score number inside each captured zone (1, 2, 3...). The zone must be large enough to fit the number — a natural size enforcer.

04

Endgame

Game ends when no more zones can be formed. Most captured zones wins — quantity over size.

Player count scales from 2–4: two players use opposite sides; four players start from each corner.

Audience

AGE

8+

Simple rules, physical dexterity not required, scales in complexity with player experience.

CONTEXT

**Classroom / Kitchen
Table**

Designed for school settings, family game nights, or any space with pen and paper.

GROUP SIZE

2 – 4 players

Works best at 2 for focused territory battles; 4 creates chaotic multi-front strategy.

SKILL FLOOR

Minimal

You can play your first game with a one-minute rules explanation.

SKILL CEILING

High

Dot placement strategy, line denial, and zone geometry create deep mastery.

Feedback & Playtesting

DESIGN ITERATIONS

v1.0

d6 roll

Flat distribution caused too many wasted 1-line turns, reducing player agency.

v1.1

2d4 roll

Bell curve centered on 5 eliminated catastrophic turns while preserving meaningful variance.

v1.2

Max 4 lines per dot

Prevented nodes from becoming infinitely dense junctions. Makes placement decisions permanent.

v1.3

Score written in zone

Self-enforces minimum zone size organically. Adds visible running score on board.

Key finding: the dot placement phase is the highest-skill layer; players underestimate it until they lose.

Conclusion



Why this game

- I've been toying with the idea of a pencil and paper game for a while
- I really wanted to make something fairly straightforward and easy to do anywhere
- I like the idea of creating a different map for each game, and struggling between size/ game length
- multiplayer seems like a cool expansion

Going forward

- I still like paper and pencil ideas and I'd like to play with the design space more
- I like incorporating different game pieces, so dice and paper/ pencil, cards, etc.
- I used to play a "dnd" game with friends at lunchtime in middle school, i made dungeons on maps and then we tossed bits of paper as coins to make "rolls"